MICRODRAMA ▼

SOME SAY **IT WITH AI**

Amita and Ram Madhvani have taken a hands-on approach to **Mohini**, *their AI musical microdrama*



For nearly two decades, Amita Madhvani had the story of a 25-year-old dancer sitting with her. With AI, she says, she could finally bring it to life. The result is *Mohini*, a 12-episode microdrama streaming on Instagram. "Rather than have reservations, we are trying to grow with the technology...otherwise, we will be left behind," says Amita.

Best known for being a key collaborator on her husband Ram Madhvani's works, like *Neerja* and *Aarya*, Amita emphasises that AI is not displacing humans. "Feelings can only be generated when humans create it," she says, and, in the case of *Mohini*, she has written both its story and lyrics. "Humans are running the tool [Google Cloud] and coming up with ideas. We are all learning AI together, with some of the crew as young as the titular character."

Prod her on why she didn't take *Mohini* to the umpteen microdrama platforms that have mushroomed in the past year, and Amita describes its making as very "hands-on". "Equinox is a very homegrown production house with a very personal approach," she says. "I have to see...does it have the expression and does it resonate?"



"RATHER THAN HAVE RESERVATIONS," SAYS **AMITA,** "WE ARE TRYING TO GROW WITH THE AI TECHNOLOGY"

AI is steadily finding its way into filmmaking worldwide. Recently, American filmmaker Martin Scorsese admitted that he uses it for storyboarding. The Madhvanis, too, have used it during the pre-production visualisation stage. "It saves you time and helps you think clearly," says Amita. ■

—Suhani Singh



RAW STORYTELLING The show premiered on Zee5 on May 22

OTT ▼

Hinterland Heartbreak

A new web series, ***SATRANGI: BADLE KA KHEL***, highlights the perilous place of Launda Naach performers in the social hierarchy

Satrangi: Badle Ka Khel, a crime thriller on ZEE5, has been getting rave reviews for its raw storytelling and powerful performances. Set against the rugged backdrop of rural Uttar Pradesh, the series stars Anshuman Pushkar, Kumud Mishra and Kashish Duggal. Exploring themes of caste discrimination, social stigma and humiliation, it narrates the story of a 'Launda Naach' (a folk dance where males dress up as women) performer's son, who secretly avenges his father's murder.

Having grown up in Varanasi, director Jai Basantu Singh spent a lot of time in eastern UP, where Launda Naach was a big part of local celebrations. As he grew older, Singh began noticing a stark contrast between the celebration of the art form and the treatment of the artists themselves. "The performers who entertained entire communities often faced judgement, ridicule and social exclusion once they stepped off the stage," he said. *Satrangi* came from that lived observation.

For Singh, cinema is about what remains unsaid. "By reducing musical cues and bringing the camera closer, we tried to create a more immersive emotional experience where viewers could feel what the characters were going through," he explains. ■

—Neha Kirpal

Director **Jai Basantu Singh** says the show offers audiences a more immersive emotional experience

